Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	close current buffer
`:bca`	close all buffers
`:bco`	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	next buffer
`␣b`	open buffer picker
`ga`	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	go to next buffer
`gp`	go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	close current split
`␣wo`	close all but current split
`␣ww`	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	align to center
`zt`	align to top
`zb`	align to bottom
`zm`	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	scroll down
`zk`	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

`:tutor`	open tutorial
`␣?`	open command palette

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

`h/j/k/l`	left / up / down / right
`gh, g|`	beginning of line
`<nn>g|`	column <nn>
`gl`	end of line
`gg`	top of file
`<nn>G, g<nn>g`	line <nn>
`ge`	bottom of file
`gw`	two-char labels on words, label to go to word
`g.`	to last modification in current file
`gj`	down textual line
`gk`	up textual line
`gs`	first non-white-space char
`gt`	top of screen
`gc`	middle of screen
`gb`	bottom of screen

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd  – go to definition
gy  – go to type definition
gr  – go to references
gi  – go to implementation

]d  – next diagnostic
[d  – prior diagnostic
]D  – last diagnostic
[D  – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f  – to next, prior function
]t, [t  – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T  – to next, prior test
]a, [a  – to next, prior arg
]c, [c  – to next, prior comment
]g, [g  – to next, prior change
]G, [G  – to last, first change

Alt-e  – move to end of parent node in syntax
         tree
Alt-b  – move to start of parent node in syntax
         tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b  – page up
Ctrl-f  – page down
Ctrl-u  – half page up
Ctrl-d  – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
%       – select whole file
Alt-;   – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-:   – selection to normal direction (cursor at
          end)
Alt-o   – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i   – shrink selection
;       – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch>  – match around / inside the object
                   indicated by <ch> below:

w / W  – word / WORD
p      – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
m      –  closest surround pair
f      – function
t      – type or class
a      – argument/parameter
c      – comment
T      – test
g      – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W  – to start of next word / WORD
e / E  – to end of current word / WORD
b / B  – to start of current word / WORD
x      – current line, extend by line
X      – extend to line
Alt-x  – shrink to line bounds
]p     – to next paragraph
[p     – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o  – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i  – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p  – select previous sibling node in syntax
         tree
Alt-n  – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a  – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I  – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch>  – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch>  – to <ch> exclusive (till)
Alt-.         – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v    – toggle select mode
Esc  – return to normal
)    – cycle primary selection forward
(    – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex>  – matches become selections
S         – split on match
Alt-s     – split on newlines
C, Alt-C  – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
&          – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus>  – merge selections
Alt-<under>  – merge consecutive selections
,          – remove all except primary selection
Alt-,      – remove primary selection
( / )      – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / )  – rotate content backward / forward
K          – keep selections matching the regex
Alt-K      – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
i – before selection
a – after selection
I – at start of line
A – at end of line
o – add line and insert below cursor
O – add line and insert above cursor
Esc – end insert (return to normal)
. – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ – newline below
[␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
Alt-c – change, no save
= – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) containing selection
< – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
~ – change case
` – set lowercase
Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
␣C – Toggle block comment
␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
J – join lines in a selection
Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the
        inserted space
<under> – trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
y – selection -> yank buf
p – paste yank buf after the cursor
P – paste yank buf before the cursor
␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before
          selections(s)
␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
R – replace selection with yank buf
" – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
n, N – next, previous match
* – search for current selection, respect
    word boundaries
Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm – go to matching delim
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
! – insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
$ – keep selection(s) where command
    returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

`␣G`	– debug - experimental
`␣k`	– show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s`	– open document symbol picker
`␣S`	– open workspace symbol picker
`␣d`	– open document diagnostics picker
`␣D`	– open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r`	– rename symbol
`␣a`	– apply code action
`␣h`	– select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

`:config-open`	– open the config file
`:config-open-workspace`	– open the workspace config file
`:config-reload`	– reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

`␣'`	– open last picker
`␣/`	– open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                Ctrl-r – insert a register content
   Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
     Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
       Ctrl-h, <bksp>,– delete previous char
         Shift-<bksp>
        Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
      Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
  <Up> <Down> <Left> – usual meaning but
    <Right> <PageUp>   discouraged
   <PageDown> <Home>
               <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
               <enter> – open selected
                 <tab> – select next completion item
             <backtab> – select previous completion
                         item
                 Alt-b – backward a word
                Ctrl-b – backward a char
                 Alt-f – forward a word
                Ctrl-f – forward a char
                Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                Ctrl-a – to prompt start
  Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
    Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
        <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
         <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc
                         cursor (may be changed to
                         Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                Ctrl-p – select previous history
                Ctrl-n – select next history
                Ctrl-r – insert the content of the
                         register selected by
                         following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
  Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p,– previous entry
                 <Up>
        <tab>, Ctrl-n,– next entry
                <Down>
                <Home> – to first entry
                 <End> – to last entry
     Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
   Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
               <enter> – open selected
          Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                        background without closing
                        the picker
                Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                Ctrl-v – open vertically
                Ctrl-t – toggle preview
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
      Ctrl-u – scroll up
      Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
  Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
        Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
            <enter> – close menu and accept
                      completion
             Ctrl-c – close menu and reject
                      completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
      Alt-p – previous signature
      Alt-n – next signature
```

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`Ctrl-e` – to prompt end **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-f` – forward a char **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-f` – page down **(2.2.4)**
`Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-i` – move forward in jumplist **(2.11)**
`Ctrl-j` – insert new line **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.5)**
`Ctrl-n` – select next history **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-o` – move backwards in jumplist **(2.11)**
`Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.5)**
`Ctrl-p` – select previous history **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-r` – insert a register content **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-r` – insert the content of the register selected by following input char **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-s` – commit undo checkpoint **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-s` – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-s` – open horizontally **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-s` – open selected in new horizontal split **(2.1.2.1)**
`Ctrl-s` – save current position to jumplist **(2.11)**
`Ctrl-t` – toggle preview **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-u` – half page up **(2.2.4)**
`Ctrl-u` – page up **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-u` – scroll up **(3.4)**
`Ctrl-v` – open selected in new vertical split **(2.1.2.1)**
`Ctrl-v` – open vertically **(3.3)**
`Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.2)**
`Ctrl-x` – autocomplete **(3.1)**
`Ctrl-x` – decrement the selected number **(2.6.8)**
`Esc` – close picker **(3.3)**
`Esc` – close prompt **(3.2)**
`Esc` – end insert (return to normal) **(2.6.1)**
`Esc` – return to normal **(2.4)**
`Esc` – return to normal mode **(2.1)**
`F<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
`I` – at start of line **(2.6.1)**
`J` – join lines in a selection **(2.6.9)**
`K` – keep selections matching the regex **(2.5.2)**
`N` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
`O` – add line and insert above cursor **(2.6.1)**
`P` – paste yank buf before the cursor **(2.7)**
`R` – replace selection with yank buf **(2.7)**
`S` – split on match **(2.5.1)**
`Shift-<bksp>` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
`Shift-<tab>` – previous entry **(3.3)**
`Shift-Tab` – previous entry **(3.5)**
`T` – test **(2.3.2)**
`T<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
`Tab` – next entry **(3.5)**
`X` – extend to line **(2.3.3)**
`Z` – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc **(2.1.4.1)**
`[␣` – newline above **(2.6.2)**
`[` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
`[D` – first diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
`[G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
`[T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
`[a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
`[c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
`[d` – prior diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
`[f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
`[g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
`[p` – to prior paragraph **(2.3.3)**
`[t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
`]␣` – newline below **(2.6.2)**
`]D` – last diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
`]G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
`]T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
`]a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
`]c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
`]d` – next diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
`]f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
`]g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
`]p` – to next paragraph **(2.3.3)**
`]t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
` ` ` – set lowercase **(2.6.6)**
`a` – after selection **(2.6.1)**
`a` – argument/parameter **(2.3.2)**
`b / B` – to start of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
`c` – comment **(2.3.2)**

`c` – selection -> yank buf, change selection **(2.6.4)**
`d` – selection -> yank buf, delete selection **(2.6.3)**
`e / E` – to end of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
`etc.` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
`f` – function **(2.3.2)**
`f<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
`g` – change git hunk **(2.3.2)**
`g.` – to last modification in current file **(2.2.1)**
`g<nn>g` – line <nn> **(2.2.1)**
`ga` – go to last accessed/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
`gb` – bottom of screen **(2.2.1)**
`gc` – middle of screen **(2.2.1)**
`gd` – go to definition **(2.2.2)**
`ge` – bottom of file **(2.2.1)**
`gf` – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. **(2.1.2)**
`gg` – top of file **(2.2.1)**
`gh` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
`gi` – go to implementation **(2.2.2)**
`gj` – down textual line **(2.2.1)**
`gk` – up textual line **(2.2.1)**
`gl` – end of line **(2.2.1)**
`gm` – go to last modified/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
`gn` – go to next buffer **(2.1.3)**
`gp` – go to previous buffer **(2.1.3)**
`gr` – go to references **(2.2.2)**
`gs` – first non-white-space char **(2.2.1)**
`gt` – top of screen **(2.2.1)**
`gw` – two-char labels on words, label to go to word **(2.2.1)**
`gy` – go to type definition **(2.2.2)**
`g|` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
`h/j/k/l` – left / up / down / right **(2.2.1)**
`i` – before selection **(2.6.1)**
`m` – closest surround pair **(2.3.2)**
`ma<ch>` – match around delim <ch> **(2.12)**
`ma<ch> /` – match around / inside the object
`mi<ch>` indicated by <ch> below: **(2.3.2)**
`md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
`md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.3)**
`mi<ch>` – match inside delim <ch> **(2.12)**
`mm` – go to matching delim **(2.12)**
`mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.12)**
`mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.6.4)**
`ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
`ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.2)**
`n` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
`o` – add line and insert below cursor **(2.6.1)**
`p` – paragraph **(2.3.2)**
`p` – paste yank buf after the cursor **(2.7)**
`r<ch>` – replace selection with <ch> **(2.7)**
`s<regex>` – matches become selections **(2.5.1)**
`t` – type or class **(2.3.2)**
`t<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
`u / U` – undo / redo change in linear history **(2.1)**
`v` – toggle select mode **(2.4)**
`w / W` – to start of next word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
`w / W` – word / WORD **(2.3.2)**
`x` – current line, extend by line **(2.3.3)**
`y` – selection -> yank buf **(2.7)**
`zb` – align to bottom **(2.1.4.1)**
`zc` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
`zj` – scroll down **(2.1.4.1)**
`zk` – scroll up **(2.1.4.1)**
`zm` – align to middle horizontally **(2.1.4.1)**
`zt` – align to top **(2.1.4.1)**
`zz` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
`|` – replace selection(s) with output **(2.13)**
`~` – change case **(2.6.6)**